But the geo-political mapping of power had shifted as the Shansabanis gained a foothold in the Bamiyan basin: rather than the area being an extension of power radiating southward throughout Tukharistan with late Hephthalite–Western Turkic control as in the sixth through ninth centuries (see above), by the later twelfth century the Bamiyan Shansabanis had to contend with disaffected Saljuq governors, the encroaching Oghüz, and the Qarakhitay, all poised to approach from the north. The Shansabani construction of Sarkhushak – boasting both palatial as well as possibly military structures, built by the architecturally skilled labor available in the region – surely aided in the vigilance against an entirely new gamut of enemies.[79] The possible reoccupation of Danestama also falls in line with these northern threats, lending further weight to a military or at least multi-faceted purpose for this complex.[80]

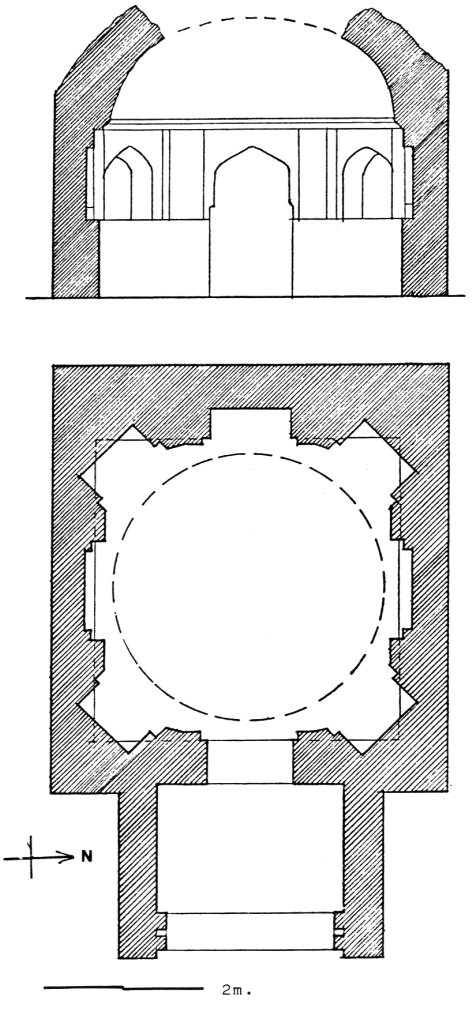


Figure 3.25 *Sarkhushak, Building E, plan and elevation. From Baker and Allchin 1996: fig. 5.18.*

If indeed the palatial complexes at Sarkhushak are attributed to Shansabani patronage, they may present something of a surprise given the archaeologically attested *absence* of a permanent royal residence at Firuzkuh (cf. above). But the temptation to compare the two agnatic lineages, and to reduce them to a seemingly necessary but ultimately artificial parity, can be avoided if we recall the great variety both *within* and *among* transhumant/nomadic groups. The acknowledged symbiosis among these multiple lifeways, effectively constituting the nomad–urban continuum, was one in which the Shansabanis had participated since pre-imperial times; in fact, it was arguably a factor in their very ascendancy as a regional elite still preserving some form of transhumance (see esp. Chapter 2).

Shansabani clansmen had already been exposed to a more sedentist lifestyle, and some may have taken it up at an earlier stage than is historically documentable. While Firuzkuh and the Hari Rud's banks continued to function as *sard-sir* for the Firuzkuh Shansabanis, the Bamiyan basin's cul-